Donut Intel Platform

Windows Setup & User Guide

A step-by-step guide to installing, setting up,
and using the Donut Intel Platform on Windows.

Version 2.1 | Written for Windows 10 and Windows 11
Read this guide from start to finish before you begin.

📋 Table of Contents

SECTION 1

Welcome — What Is Donut Intel?

Donut Intel is a computer program that helps you keep track of products and prices across multiple stores on the internet. Think of it like having a very smart assistant who visits websites every day, writes down what everything costs, and tells you when a competitor is selling something cheaper than you are.

What Can It Do?

- 📦 **Collect products** — It visits your websites and saves a list of every product you sell, along with its price.
- 🏪 **Watch competitors** — It searches the internet for stores that sell the same things you do and records their prices.
- 💰 **Compare prices** — It shows you side-by-side price comparisons so you can see if someone is cheaper than you.
- 🔁 **Find duplicates** — It notices when the same product is listed more than once and helps you clean up your catalog.
- 🛍️ **Connect to Shopify** — It can sync product information directly to your Shopify store.
- ⏰ **Run automatically** — You can set it to do all of this on a schedule, so you don't have to remember to run it.
- 📤 **Export data** — It can save your product data to a spreadsheet file (Excel or CSV) that you can share with others.

Who Is This Guide For?

This guide is written for anyone setting up Donut Intel on a Windows computer. You do **not** need to be a programmer. All you need is the ability to follow step-by-step instructions. If you can copy files and type commands, you can set this up.

> 📖 **How to Use This Guide**
>
> Follow the sections in order from top to bottom the first time you set up the app. After that, you can jump to any section to look up how to use a specific feature.

SECTION 2

What You Need Before Starting

Computer Requirements

Item	Minimum	Recommended
Operating System	Windows 10 (64-bit)	Windows 11
Memory (RAM)	4 GB	8 GB or more
Free Disk Space	5 GB	10 GB or more
Internet Connection	Required for setup	Required for all scanning features
Web Browser	Edge, Chrome, or Firefox	Google Chrome

> ⚠️ **Important — 64-bit Windows Required**
> This app only works on 64-bit versions of Windows. To check yours: click the **Start** button, type **About your PC**, press Enter, and look for "System type." It should say "64-bit operating system."

How Much Time You'll Need

- **First-time setup:** About 20–30 minutes (mostly waiting for downloads)
- **Configuration:** About 10 minutes
- **Learning to use the app:** About 1 hour to read this guide and explore

Helpful Things to Know Beforehand

You will need to know the **username** and **password** you want to use to log into the app. The default is `admin` / `changeme`, but you will change this during setup.

If you use Shopify or want to search for competitor prices using services like SerpAPI or Anthropic AI, you will need your **API keys** from those services. An **API key** is like a password that lets the app talk to another service. If you don't have these, that's fine — most features work without them.

SECTION 3

Step 1 — Install Python

Python is the programming language that Donut Intel is built with. Think of it as the "engine" that makes the app run. You need to install it before anything else.

Download Python

🌐 **Download Python Here:**

https://www.python.org/downloads/windows/

Look for the most recent version of **Python 3.11** or **Python 3.12**. Click the link that says **"Windows installer (64-bit)"**.

Install Python — Step by Step

1. Find the file you just downloaded. It will be in your **Downloads** folder. Its name will look like `python-3.12.x-amd64.exe`. Double-click it to start the installer.

2. **Very important:** At the bottom of the first screen, check the box that says **"Add python.exe to PATH"**. This step is critical — if you skip it, nothing will work.

   ⚠️ **Check This Box Before Clicking Install!**

   "Add python.exe to PATH" is at the *bottom* of the installer window. It is easy to miss. If you forget, uninstall Python and start over.

3. Click **"Install Now"** (the big blue button at the top). Windows may ask permission — click **Yes**.

4. Wait for the installation to finish. It usually takes 1–3 minutes. When done, you will see a screen that says **"Setup was successful."** Click **Close**.

5. **Verify the installation:** Press the **Windows key** on your keyboard, type `cmd`, and press **Enter**. A black window called **Command Prompt** will open. Type the following and press Enter:

```
python --version
```

You should see something like `Python 3.12.3`. If you see that, Python is installed correctly! Close this window.

> 💡 **What Is Command Prompt?**
>
> Command Prompt is a special window where you type instructions to the computer. Instead of clicking buttons, you type commands. It looks like a black screen with white text. You will use it a few times to set up and manage this app.

SECTION 4

Step 2 — Get the App Files

Where to Put the Files

Save the app folder to this location on your computer:

```
C:\DonutIntel
```

This means the app files will be at `C:\DonutIntel\`. Your app window, Command Prompt, and all the instructions in this guide assume the files are here. If you put them somewhere else, you will need to adjust the folder paths shown in this guide.

Copy the Files

1. You have received a ZIP file called `DonutIntel-Windows.zip`. Find it in your **Downloads** folder (or wherever it was sent to you).
2. Right-click the ZIP file and choose **"Extract All..."**
3. In the window that appears, type `C:\` as the destination and click **Extract**. This will create the folder `C:\DonutIntel\` with all the app files inside.
4. Open **File Explorer** (the folder icon in your taskbar) and navigate to `C:\DonutIntel`. You should see a list of files including `setup.bat`, `start.bat`, `stop.bat`, and folders like `backend` and `frontend`. If you see these files, you're ready for the next step!

📁 **What's Inside the App Folder?**

File / Folder	What It Is
`setup.bat`	First-time setup — double-click this once
`start.bat`	Start the app — double-click to turn it on
`stop.bat`	Stop the app — double-click to turn it off

`start.py` / `stop.py` / `setup_env.py`	The scripts the .bat files run (for advanced users)
`generate_certs.py`	Creates security certificates
`cli.py`	Command line tools
`requirements.txt`	List of extra software the app needs
`backend\`	The "brain" of the app (don't edit these files)
`frontend\`	The visual parts of the app (the website pages)
`config\settings.yaml`	Your settings and API keys
`data\`	Where your product database is stored
`logs\`	Activity records (like a diary of what the app did)
`exports\`	Where exported spreadsheet files are saved
`certs\`	Security certificates for the HTTPS connection

SECTION 5

Step 3 — Run First-Time Setup

The setup script does four things automatically:

1. Creates a private Python **environment** (a separate space for the app's software)
2. Downloads and installs all the extra software the app needs
3. Downloads the **Chromium** and **Firefox** browser engines (used for web scraping)
4. Creates the security **certificates** so the app can use a secure HTTPS connection

Open Command Prompt and Go to the App Folder

1. Press the **Windows key**, type `cmd`, and press **Enter**. Command Prompt opens — a black window with a blinking cursor.

2. Type the following command and press **Enter**:

```
cd C:\DonutIntel
```

The line at the bottom of the window will now say `C:\DonutIntel>`. This means you are "inside" the app folder.

Run the Setup Script

> ✅ **Easiest way**
>
> Open the `C:\DonutIntel` folder and **double-click** **`setup.bat`** . It does the steps below for you. Then skip to Section 6.

3. Or, in Command Prompt, type the following and press **Enter**:

```
python setup_env.py
```

4. The setup script will start. You will see messages scrolling by. **This will take 5–15 minutes** — it is downloading files from the internet. Do not close the window. Just wait until you see:

```
Setup complete!
```

When you see that, setup is done. On Windows the easiest way to start and stop the app is to double-click `start.bat` and `stop.bat` (covered in the next steps).

> 💡 **Something Went Wrong?**
>
> If you see a red error message that says **"python is not recognized"**, Python was not installed correctly — specifically, the "Add Python to PATH" box was not checked. Uninstall Python from **Control Panel** → **Programs** and reinstall it, making sure to check that box.

> 💡 **Setup Already Run?**
>
> If you run `setup_env.py` again later, it will skip steps that are already done. It is safe to run multiple times.

SECTION 6

Step 4 — Configure Your Settings

Before you start the app for the first time, you need to open the settings file and make a few changes. The settings file is a plain text file called `settings.yaml`. It controls everything about how the app behaves — your login password, your website addresses, and more.

Open the Settings File

1. Open **File Explorer** and navigate to `C:\DonutIntel\config\`.
2. Right-click the file `settings.yaml` and choose **"Open with"**, then select **Notepad** (or any text editor you have).

> 💡 **Better Text Editors (Optional)**
>
> Notepad works fine, but if you want colored text that makes the file easier to read, you can download one of these free programs:
>
> - **Notepad++:** https://notepad-plus-plus.org/downloads/
> - **VS Code:** https://code.visualstudio.com/

Required Changes

> ⚠️ **Do These Changes Before Starting the App**
>
> The settings below use example placeholder values. You must replace them with your own.

Change Your Login Password

Find this section in the file:

```
auth:
  enabled: true
  username: admin
  password: changeme
```

Change `changeme` to a password only you know. Example:

```
auth:
  enabled: true
  username: admin
  password: MySecretPassword123!
```

Change the Secret Key

Find this line:

```
  secret_key: CHANGE_ME_REPLACE_WITH_RANDOM_32_CHARACTER_STRING
```

Replace the value with any random string of letters and numbers that is at least 32 characters long. You can make one up — just a random mix of letters and numbers. Example (do not use this exact one):

```
  secret_key: xK9mP2qL7nR4vT1wY8sA5jB3hC6dE0fZ
```

Set the Browser Profile for Windows

Find this section:

```
browser:
  default_profile: safari_mac
```

Change it to:

```
browser:
  default_profile: chrome_windows
```

Optional Settings

Add Your Source Websites

The `source_sites` section lists the websites the app will scrape for products. Each entry has fields like `domain`, `base_url`, and Shopify credentials. If you have a Shopify store, fill in your API key and access token here. You can change these settings in the app's Settings screen too (see Section 10).

Add API Keys (Optional)

If you have a **SerpAPI** key (for Google Shopping searches), find this section and add it:

```
serpapi:
  api_key: YOUR_SERPAPI_KEY_HERE
```

If you have an **Anthropic** API key (for AI-powered product categorization), find this section:

```
anthropic:
  api_key: YOUR_ANTHROPIC_KEY_HERE
  enabled: false
```

Change `enabled: false` to `enabled: true` to turn on AI features.

Save the File

After making your changes, press **Ctrl+S** to save. Close the text editor.

> ⚠️ **Keep This File Private**
>
> The `settings.yaml` file contains your passwords and API keys. Do not email it or share it with anyone. Do not upload it to the internet.

SECTION 7

Step 5 — Start the App

Starting the app means turning on the **server** — the program that runs in the background and serves the web dashboard to your browser. Think of it like turning on a TV before you can watch it.

How to Start

✅ **Easiest way**

Open the `C:\DonutIntel` folder and **double-click** **`start.bat`** . A black window opens, the app turns on, and your web browser opens the app for you after a few seconds.

1. In **File Explorer**, open `C:\DonutIntel`.
2. Double-click `start.bat`. You will see a message like this:

```
Starting Donut Intel Platform on https://localhost:8800
  API docs: https://localhost:8800/api/docs
  Press Ctrl+C to stop
```

The app is now running! **Leave the black window open** — closing it turns the app off.

💡 **Prefer to type commands?**

Open Command Prompt and run:

```
cd C:\DonutIntel
.venv\Scripts\python start.py
```

Use the app's own Python in `.venv\Scripts` — the plain `python start.py` will not find the app's packages.

💡 **Keep the Window Open**

> The black window *must stay open* while you use the app. You can minimize it (the minus button), but do not close it.

SECTION 8

Step 6 — Open the App in Your Browser

Go to the App Website

1. Open your web browser (Chrome, Firefox, or Edge).
2. In the address bar at the top, type the following address exactly and press Enter:

```
https://localhost:8800
```

Accept the Security Notice

Because the app uses a **self-signed certificate** (a security certificate you created yourself), your browser will show a warning. **This is normal and safe.** The app is only running on your own computer — it is not on the public internet.

In Google Chrome:

1. You will see a page that says **"Your connection is not private"**
2. Click **"Advanced"** (at the bottom of the page)
3. Click **"Proceed to localhost (unsafe)"**

In Microsoft Edge:

1. You will see a page that says **"Your connection isn't private"**
2. Click **"Advanced"**
3. Click **"Continue to localhost (unsafe)"**

In Mozilla Firefox:

1. You will see a page that says **"Warning: Potential Security Risk Ahead"**
2. Click **"Advanced…"**
3. Click **"Accept the Risk and Continue"**

> 💡 **Only Needed Once Per Browser**
>
> After you accept the warning once, your browser remembers and will not ask again (until you clear your browser data or switch computers).

Log In

1. You will see a login page. Enter your username and password. (Default: `admin` / the password you set in Step 4.)
2. Click **Sign In**. The dashboard will load and you're in!

SECTION 9

Step 7 — Stop the App

Method 1 — The Easiest Way

Open the `C:\DonutIntel` folder and **double-click** **`stop.bat`**. You will see: `Stopped 1 process(es).`

Method 2 — Quick Stop

Click on the black window where the app is running, then press **Ctrl+C** on your keyboard. The app will stop gracefully. (Or just close that window.)

> ⚠️ **Always Stop Before Turning Off Your Computer**
>
> Stop the app before shutting down or restarting Windows. The database is safe — it uses a technology called WAL mode that protects your data — but it is good practice to stop the app cleanly.

SECTION 10

All Features Explained (The Menu)

The dashboard is the main screen of the app. It is a website that opens in your browser. On the left side is a **sidebar** — a list of buttons that take you to different sections. Here is what each section does and how to use it.

📊 Dashboard — The Home Screen

See everything at a glance

The Dashboard is the first page you see when you log in. It shows you a quick summary of everything: how many products you have, when the app last ran a scan, and any recent activity. There is also a **live log viewer** at the bottom — a scrolling window that shows you exactly what the app is doing right now, in real time.

What You'll See:

- **Stats cards** — Total products, source listings, pending duplicates, new products found recently
- **Products by site** — How many products come from each of your websites
- **Last scan status** — When did the app last check your websites for new products?
- **Live log** — A running record of what the app is currently doing (you can filter by Info, Warning, or Critical messages)

🔍 Scans — View Scan History

See what the app has done and what it found

Every time the app visits a website and collects product information, that is called a **scan**. The Scans section shows you a history of every scan: when it ran, how long it took, how many products it found, and whether it succeeded or failed.

How to Use It:

1. Click **Scans** in the left sidebar.
2. You will see a list of recent scans with their status (Completed, Running, or Failed).
3. Click a scan to see the details — which products were found or updated.
4. If a scan is still running, you will see a **Cancel** button next to it.

🔁 Duplicates — Clean Up Double Listings

Find and remove products listed more than once

When the app scrapes multiple websites, it sometimes finds the same product listed in more than one place. The Duplicates section shows you these suspected matches and lets you decide what to do — **merge** them into one record, or **reject** the match if they are actually different products.

How to Use It:

1. Click **Duplicates** in the left sidebar.
2. Each row shows two products that look similar, with a **match score** (0–100%). Higher scores mean they are more likely to be the same product.
3. Click **Merge** to combine them into one product.
4. Click **Reject** if they are different products and you do not want to merge them.
5. You can also run the automatic deduplication by going to **Dashboard** → **Run Dedup**.

🔀 Store Compare — Products Across Your Sites

Are the same products on all your stores?

If you have products on multiple websites, Store Compare helps you find any products that are missing from one site but present on another, and shows you where the same product has different prices across your stores. A **Gaps** bar at the top shows how many products each store is missing — click a store's chip to see just those products.

How to Use It:

1. Click **Store Compare** in the left sidebar.
2. Select two sites to compare from the dropdowns.
3. The app will show you products that exist on one site but not the other, and flag products where the prices are different.

🛍️ Shopify Sync — Send Products to Shopify

Push your product catalog to a Shopify store

If you use **Shopify** (an online store platform), this feature lets you export your product data directly to your Shopify store. You choose which products to send, how to handle conflicts, and the app will update your Shopify store automatically. *You need a Shopify API key configured in settings to use this feature.*

How to Use It:

1. Click **Shopify Sync** in the left sidebar.
2. Choose a source site from the dropdown.
3. Configure how to handle existing products (merge, replace, or skip).
4. Click **Preview** to see what changes will be made.
5. Click **Execute Sync** to send the data to Shopify.

⚡ Live Sync — Push Changes Into a Shopify Store

Copy product info from one Shopify store into another

Live Sync copies product information **from one Shopify store (the source) into another (the destination)**. Only the destination is changed — the source is read-only and never touched. It walks you through five steps: **Set up** → **Preview** → **Review & approve** → **Apply** → **Done**.

How to Use It:

1. **Set up:** pick a Source store and a Destination store. Tick the fields to copy (Title, Description, Vendor, Product Type, Tags, Variants & Pricing, Images, Collections) using the checkbox under each one. Optionally turn on “Include new products” or, carefully, “Include deletes.”
2. Click **“Compare Stores & Preview Changes.”** This only looks — nothing is written yet.
3. **Review & approve:** every proposed change shows its old value, new value, and warnings. Filter the list by product characteristic (Title, Images, Tags, and so on). Approve or reject each one, or use the Approve/Reject buttons.
4. **Apply:** click “Apply N Approved Change(s).” Only the changes you approved are written to the destination store.

Needs Shopify keys in Settings.

🔄 Source Sync — Sync Products Between Your Sites

Make sure all your sites have the same products

If you run several websites (such as a wholesale site and a retail site), Source Sync helps you keep them all consistent. It compares your sites to find missing products or pricing mismatches and lets you approve changes to sync them up.

How to Use It:

1. Click **Source Sync** in the left sidebar.
2. Choose which sites to compare.
3. Review the differences — missing products are shown in one list, price differences in another.
4. Click **Approve** on each change you want to make, or **Reject** to skip it.
5. Click **Run Cycle** to apply all approved changes.

🏛️ System of Record — Set Your Primary Data Source

Which site is the "true" version of your product data?

When you have products on multiple sites, one of them needs to be the **master** — the one you trust most. System of Record lets you pick that primary site and then compare all other sites against it. It has four tabs: Missing, Differing, Matching, and Fuzzy (close but not exact matches).

⏰ Scheduler — Automate Tasks

Set the app to run scans automatically on a schedule

Instead of manually starting scans every day, you can set up a schedule. For example: "Scan all source sites every morning at 9 AM" or "Check competitor prices every Monday at 7 AM." The app handles the rest automatically, even if you are not at your computer.

How to Create a Scheduled Job:

1. Click **Scheduler** in the left sidebar.
2. Click **"New Job"**.
3. Give it a name, choose a job type (e.g., Source Scan, Competitor Scan, Export).
4. Choose when to run it: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, or a custom schedule (cron).
5. Click **Save**. The job will now run automatically at the time you set.
6. You can also click **"Run Now"** next to any job to run it immediately.

📋 Reports — Generate Summary Documents

Create printable reports about your catalog and pricing

The Reports section lets you generate HTML reports you can read or save. There are four types:

- **Summary** — Overview of your catalog over the last N days
- **Price Disparity** — Products where competitor prices differ by more than a certain percentage
- **Competitor Profile** — Everything the app knows about one specific competitor
- **Price Comparison** — Full price history for one specific product

How to Use It:

1. Click **Reports** in the left sidebar.
2. Choose a report type from the dropdown.
3. Fill in any required details (competitor ID, number of days, etc.).
4. Click **Generate**. The report opens in the same window.
5. Click **Download** to save the report as an HTML file.

📤 Export — Download Your Data as a Spreadsheet

Save your product catalog to Excel or CSV

Export lets you download your entire product catalog (or a filtered portion) as a spreadsheet file. You can open it in Microsoft Excel or Google Sheets. Files are saved to the `exports` folder inside the app.

How to Use It:

1. Click **Export** in the left sidebar.
2. Choose a format: **CSV** (works in Excel and Google Sheets), **XLSX** (Excel format), or **TXT** (plain text).
3. Choose which fields (columns) to include in the export.
4. Click **Export**. The file will download to your browser's Downloads folder.
5. Past exports are listed at the bottom so you can re-download them.

⚙️ Settings — Configure the App

Change passwords, API keys, and behavior

The Settings screen lets you change most app configuration directly from the browser — no need to edit `settings.yaml` by hand. Changes take effect immediately without restarting the app.

Tab	What You Can Do
Auth	Change your login username and password, enable/disable login, set session timeout
Database	See where your database is stored, run a backup, change the database path
Webhook	Set up a URL that receives notifications when scans finish or prices change
Shopify	Add or change API keys for each Shopify store
Logging	Choose how detailed the log should be (INFO = normal, DEBUG = very detailed)
Scraping	Control how fast/slow the app scrapes (delays, timeouts, retries)
AI (Anthropic)	Enter your Anthropic API key and enable AI product categorization
Managed Lists	Add domains to exclude from competitor results, add known manufacturer URLs

SECTION 11

Command Line Tools (Advanced)

The **Command Line** is a way to run tasks by typing commands instead of clicking buttons. You don't need to use these for everyday tasks — the web dashboard handles most things. But these commands are useful for automating tasks, running bulk operations, or doing things quickly.

📌 **How to Run a Command**

1. Open Command Prompt (Windows key → type `cmd` → Enter)
2. Type: `cd C:\DonutIntel` and press Enter
3. Type the command shown below and press Enter

All commands start with `python cli.py` followed by the command name.

Available Commands

scan — Scrape Your Source Websites

Visits your source websites and collects all their products and prices.

```
python cli.py scan
```

To scan just one specific website:

```
python cli.py scan --site donut-supplies.com
```

competitor-scan — Scan Competitor Websites

Visits competitor websites in your database and collects their products and prices.

```
python cli.py competitor-scan
```

To scan one specific competitor:

```
python cli.py competitor-scan --domain example.com
```

yahoo-scan — Search Yahoo Shopping for Prices

Searches Yahoo Shopping (product listing ads) for competitor prices for your products.

```
python cli.py yahoo-scan
```

To search for a specific product by ID:

```
python cli.py yahoo-scan --product-id 42
```

To search using a custom search phrase:

```
python cli.py yahoo-scan --query "commercial donut fryer"
```

import-competitors — Add Competitor Domains

Import a list of competitor websites all at once.

To import from a text file (one domain per line):

```
python cli.py import-competitors --file C:\competitors.txt
```

To add a few domains directly on the command line:

```
python cli.py import-competitors --domains competitor1.com competitor2.com
```

dedup — Find and Merge Duplicate Products

Runs the automatic duplicate-detection engine. It will find products that look like duplicates and either merge them automatically (high confidence) or flag them for your review (lower confidence).

```
python cli.py dedup
```

stats — Show App Statistics

Prints a summary of what's in your database: number of products, competitors, scans, and more.

```
python cli.py stats
```

export — Export Product Data to a File

Saves your product catalog to a spreadsheet or text file.

```
python cli.py export --format csv
```

To export as Excel format:

```
python cli.py export --format xlsx
```

To save to a specific file:

```
python cli.py export --format csv --output C:\Users\YourName\Desktop\produ
```

report — Generate a Report

Creates an HTML report you can open in your browser.

```
python cli.py report --type summary
```

Available report types:

Command	What It Generates
`--type summary`	Overview of catalog activity (last 7 days by default)
`--type summary --days 30`	Overview for the last 30 days
`--type disparity --threshold 5`	Products where a competitor is more than 5% cheaper
`--type competitor --id 12`	Full profile of competitor #12
`--type price --id 42`	Full price history for product #42

dbpath — View or Change the Database Location

Shows where your database file is saved.

```
python cli.py dbpath
```

To move it to a new location (takes effect after restart):

```
python cli.py dbpath --set C:\Users\YourName\Documents\donut_intel.db
```

schedule — Manage Scheduled Jobs

List, create, run, and delete automatic scheduled tasks.

See all scheduled jobs:

```
python cli.py schedule list
```

Create a daily scan at 9:00 AM:

```
python cli.py schedule create --name "Daily Scan" --job-type source_scan -
```

Run a job immediately (replace 1 with the job ID from `schedule list`):

```
python cli.py schedule run --id 1
```

Delete a job:

```
python cli.py schedule delete --id 1
```

SECTION 12

Automatic Scheduled Tasks

Scheduled tasks let the app run on autopilot. You set them up once and they run automatically — no need to remember to do anything each day.

> ⚠️ **The App Must Be Running for Scheduled Tasks to Work**
>
> Scheduled tasks only run while the app's server is running (i.e., while `start.bat` is running). If the app is stopped, scheduled tasks will not fire. Consider keeping the app running at all times on a dedicated machine or server.

Types of Scheduled Jobs

Job Type	What It Does
`source_scan`	Visits your source websites and collects updated products and prices
`competitor_scan`	Visits competitor websites and collects their products and prices
`export`	Automatically exports your catalog to a spreadsheet file
`price_check`	Checks for price changes and logs any differences

Schedule Formats

Type	Format	Example	Meaning
Daily	`HH:MM`	`09:00`	Every day at 9:00 AM
Weekly	`day:HH:MM`	`mon:07:30`	Every Monday at 7:30 AM
Monthly	`date:HH:MM`	`1:08:00`	1st of each month at 8:00 AM
Interval	minutes	`60`	Every 60 minutes

Recommended Setup for Most Users

📅 **Suggested Daily Schedule**

- **6:00 AM** — Source scan (collect your latest products)
- **7:00 AM** — Competitor scan (check competitor prices)
- **8:00 AM** — Export (save a fresh spreadsheet)

Set these up once in the Scheduler tab and the app does the rest.

SECTION 13

Troubleshooting

Here are the most common problems and how to fix them.

Problem	Most Likely Cause	Solution
"python is not recognized" error in Command Prompt	Python is not installed, or "Add to PATH" was not checked	Uninstall Python and reinstall it. On the first screen of the installer, check "Add python.exe to PATH" before clicking Install.
Browser shows "This site can't be reached" at `https://localhost:8800`	The app is not running	Open the app folder and double-click `start.bat`. Keep the black window it opens open.
Browser shows a security warning (certificate error)	Self-signed certificate — expected behavior	This is normal. Click "Advanced" then "Proceed to localhost (unsafe)." See Section 8 for detailed steps.
`setup_env.py` fails with "error: Microsoft Visual C++ required"	A Python package needs C++ build tools	Download and install "Microsoft C++ Build Tools" from: **https://visualstudio.microsoft.com/visual-cpp-build-tools/**
Scan runs but finds no products	Source site URLs are not configured, or the site changed its layout	Check that `source_sites` in settings.yaml has the correct domain and base_url for your websites.
"Address already in use" error when starting	A previous instance of the app is still running	Double-click `stop.bat` first, then `start.bat`.

Login page says "Invalid username or password"	Wrong password in settings, or settings not saved	Open `config\settings.yaml` and double-check the `auth.password` value. Make sure you saved the file.
`setup_env.py` stops at "Installing Playwright browser engines"	Slow internet connection or firewall blocking downloads	Wait — this step can take 5–10 minutes on a slow connection. If it fails, run `python setup_env.py` again to resume.
Port 8800 is blocked by a firewall or antivirus	Security software blocking the port	Add an exception for port 8800 in your Windows Firewall settings, or change the port in `config\settings.yaml` under `app.port`.

Getting Help

If you are still stuck, check the log files in the `C:\DonutIntel\logs\` folder. The file `donut_intel.log` contains a detailed record of what the app did and any errors it encountered. You can open it in Notepad.

Glossary — Words and What They Mean

API / API Key

An *API (Application Programming Interface)* is a way for two computer programs to talk to each other. An *API key* is like a password that proves you have permission to use that service. For example, a SerpAPI key lets this app ask Google Shopping for price information.

Browser Engine

A program that can load and understand web pages — like the inside of a web browser without the user interface. Chromium (used by Chrome) and Firefox are examples. The app uses these engines to visit websites and read their content.

Certificate / SSL Certificate

A file that proves a website is secure and creates an encrypted connection. The "S" in "HTTPS" stands for Secure. This app uses a *self-signed certificate* — one you created yourself — which is why browsers show a warning. It is still secure for local use.

Command Prompt

A black window where you type text commands to control your computer. Also called "CMD" or "Terminal." You use it to start the app, run scans, and more.

Competitor

In this app, a competitor is any website that sells products similar to yours. The app tracks competitor prices so you can compare them to your own.

CSV / XLSX

File formats for spreadsheets. *CSV (Comma-Separated Values)* is a simple format that works in any spreadsheet program. *XLSX* is the Microsoft Excel format. Both can be opened in Excel or Google Sheets.

Dashboard

The main screen of a computer program, showing a summary of everything at once — like the dashboard of a car that shows speed, fuel level, and warning lights.

Database

A file that stores information in an organized way so it can be searched and updated quickly. This app uses a database called SQLite to store all your products, prices, and competitor data. Your database file is at `data\donut_intel.db`.

Deduplication / Dedup

The process of finding duplicate records (things listed more than once) and merging them into a single record. If the same product was scraped from two different websites, dedup will notice they are the same product and combine them.

Domain

The address of a website, like `amazon.com` or `competitor-store.com`. When you add a competitor, you enter their domain.

Export

Saving data from the app to a file on your computer that you can use elsewhere, like a spreadsheet.

HTTPS

A secure version of the web. The "S" stands for Secure. When a website address starts with `https://`, the connection between your browser and the website is encrypted (scrambled) so no one can spy on it.

localhost

A special address that means "this computer." When you visit `https://localhost:8800`, your browser is connecting to a web server running on your own machine — not the internet.

Match Score

A number from 0 to 100% that says how similar two things are. A score of 100% means they are identical. A score of 60% means they are probably the same but with some differences. The app uses match scores to identify duplicate products and competitor price matches.

PATH (Environment Variable)

A list of folders that Windows searches when you type a command. When you check "Add Python to PATH" during installation, it tells Windows where to find Python so you can type `python` in Command Prompt without typing the full path to the program.

Port

Like a door number on a computer. Multiple programs can run at the same time, each listening on a different port number. This app uses port `8800`, which is why the address ends with `:8800`.

Python

A popular programming language used to build many kinds of software, including this app. It is free and works on all major operating systems.

Scan / Scraping

When the app visits a website and reads all the product information it finds there. The act of automatically reading a website's content is called *web scraping*.

Scheduler

A feature that runs tasks automatically at set times — like an alarm clock for the app.

Server

A program that runs in the background and responds to requests. When you double-click `start.bat`, you are starting the app's server. Your browser connects to this server to show you the dashboard.

Shopify

A popular e-commerce platform for building online stores. If your store runs on Shopify, this app can connect to it using a Shopify API key to sync product data.

Virtual Environment (.venv)

A private, isolated copy of Python that only this app uses. This prevents conflicts with other Python programs on your computer. The `setup_env.py` script creates this automatically in the `.venv` folder.

YAML (.yaml file)

A type of text file used to store settings in a human-readable format. The `settings.yaml` file uses this format. It is organized with categories and sub-items, like an outline.
